Journal of Advertising Research



ISSN: 0021-8499 (Print) 1740-1909 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/ujar20

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To cite this article: Steve Oakes (2007) Evaluating Empirical Research into Music in Advertising: A Congruity Perspective, Journal of Advertising Research, 47:1, 38-50, DOI: 10.2501/S0021849907070055

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.2501/S0021849907070055

Published online: 01 Mar 2007.

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Evaluating Empirical Research into Music in Advertising: A Congruity Perspective

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This research provides a review and analysis of empirical studies focusing upon cognitive and affective response to music in advertising. It draws together an apparently disparate literature to reach conclusions that will be valuable to advertising practitioners and academics. Findings are categorized by introducing 10 original definitions of music/advertising congruity (score, mood, repetition, association, valence, semantic, genre, image, tempo, and timbre). This highlights the emergence of a coherent pattern in which increased music/advertising congruity contributes synergistically to communications effectiveness by enhancing purchase intent, brand attitude, recall facilitation, and affective response. However, additional evidence indicates that future research should assess the benefits of using more artfully incongruous musical stimuli.

THE INFLUENCE OF MUSIC upon cognitive and affective response to advertising has received less attention than it may deserve, perhaps because existing empirical research has frequently produced contradictory findings, thus making it problematic for researchers to distill meaningful conclusions. Consequently, this research seeks to review the literature with the intent to identify underlying patterns that allow appropriate categorization of findings. The research incorporates discrete sections highlighting the most prominent dependent and independent variables analyzed in the literature. Table 1 is provided to inform academic research and practitioner decision making when considering musical stimuli to facilitate achievement of desired advertising outcomes. It summarizes the impact of 10 variants of congruity between musical stimulus and advertisement upon purchase intent, brand attitude, recall facilitation, and affective response. In addition, it highlights the importance of incongruity resolution.

Key dimensions of congruity identified by Heckler and Childers (1992) include relevancy (whether stimulus information contributes to or detracts from clear identification of a message and its meaning) and expectancy (whether stimulus information is consistent with an individual's prior knowledge structures associated with a given theme). The musical congruity perspective is used as a unifying framework to reconcile apparently disparate findings. Identification of an underlying dichotomy in the use of congruous or incongruous musical stimuli is designed to crystallize advertising thought by revealing how various forms of musical congruity have successfully achieved desired outcomes in empirical studies.

Bruner (1990) reviewed the literature examining the use of music in both advertising and service environment contexts, while Oakes (2000) introduced the Musicscape as a visual synthesis of empirical research into the influence of background music specifically within service environments. In contrast, this literature review examines empirical research into the impact of manipulation of musical variables within a purely advertising context. By drawing together apparently disparate studies, common themes that are explicitly stated or tacitly implied (e.g., the influence of advertising involvement) will be identified. To provide a more coherent exposition of the literature,

DOI: 10.2501/S0021849907070055

Identification of an underlying dichotomy in the use of congruous or incongruous musical stimuli is designed to crystallize advertising thought by revealing how various forms of musical congruity have successfully achieved desired outcomes in empirical studies.

terminology has been standardized. For example, the more frequently employed term "musical congruity" is used to replace alternative but equivalent authorial terms such as "musical fit" (e.g., MacInnis and Park, 1991).

There is a need for consolidation and appraisal of the existing literature on music in advertising, particularly because music forms such a considerable component of advertising communication in its various forms including instrumental background music (no lyrics), chart hits, and customized jingles (advertising compositions with lyrics). Most television advertisements consist of carefully orchestrated combinations of sight and sound. Indeed, some studies indicate that the estimated number of television advertisements using music is in excess of 90 percent, and in addition, music is perceived to be the main creative ingredient in many advertisements (Kellaris, Cox, and Cox, 1993). Its importance is reflected in the size of fees that can be commanded for creative composition or rights to use of a popular song. Microsoft paid $3 million to use The Rolling Stones' song "Start Me Up" (Naughton, 1999) during the Windows 95 launch. Such expenditure on a single transaction suggests that worldwide annual expenditure on music in advertising is likely to be worth billions of dollars. It may also indicate the desire of advertisers to have their products associated with the success and popularity of famous performers, and reflects the brand benefits of selecting a song with appropriate lyrics and imagery.

Choice of musical genre is also important, because research (Oakes, 2003a) indicates that genres (e.g., jazz and pop music) differ widely in their appeal to different demographic segments (e.g., by age, gender, education level, lifestyle, and family life cycle stage). However, many advertisers use the less expensive option of original background music produced by subcontracted advertising agency musicians. The precise use of such background music is infrequently built into creative advertising planning in the initial stages and is often merely an afterthought. While advertising agency executives must be verbally and visually adept, it may be a matter of chance whether agent or client has any musical experience or interest beyond familiarity with chart hit songs (Dunbar, 1990).

Yalch (1991) identified conflicting evidence regarding the commercial effectiveness of advertising music, because studies have highlighted how it can affect listeners by positively enhancing recall of an accompanying message, or by negatively impacting upon comprehension of meaning of the accompanying message. Such conflicting reports regarding the effectiveness of advertising music underline the need for more research to provide managers with a greater insight into the likely effects of specific musical variables upon listeners. Increased knowledge regarding the precise benefits offered by different musical alternatives will make it easier to evaluate and discriminate between those alternatives in order to ascertain the optimum selection. In this context specifically, it is important that client organizations and advertising agencies that commission original music or purchase the rights to use established music in advertisements should become more critically discriminating in evaluating the likely effects of the music upon consumers.

Many studies highlighted in the following review used student participants in an artificial environment in which they were instructed to focus their attention actively upon the advertising stimulus. It is acknowledged that in a more naturalistic setting, advertising music operates in a passive listening context. Regarding the studies highlighted in Table 1, some used television advertisements (Bozman, Mueling, and Pettit-O'Malley, 1994; Gorn, Goldberg, Chattopadhyay, and Litvack, 1991; Hung, 2000; Hung, 2001; MacInnis and Park, 1991; Park and Young, 1986; Stewart, Farmer, and Stannard, 1990; Stewart and Punj, 1998), others used static visual slides accompanied by music (Alpert, Alpert, and Maltz, 2005; Blair and Shimp, 1992; Mitchell, 1988), while the rest used radio advertising stimuli. The empirical studies have been broken down into three discrete categories of dependent variable in terms of cognitive response (purchase intent, brand attitude, and recall facilitation). Just two studies specifically examined affective response as a dependent variable.

COGNITIVE RESPONSE

Purchase intent

North, Hargreaves, MacKenzie, and Law (2004) reported the findings of a study in

TABLE 1
Empirical Findings Highlighting the Impact of Musical Congruity

Dependent Variable	Music/Advertising	Outcomes	Studies
Purchase intent	Score congruity	Music composed specifically to be appropriate with an advertisement increased purchase intent.	North, Hargreaves, MacKenzie, and Law (2004)
	Mood congruity	Increased purchase intent arose with high congruity between the mood induced by the music ("sad") and the product (greeting card for ill friend).	Alpert, Alpert, and Maltz (2005)
Brand attitude	Repetition congruity	Brand attitude enhanced as repetition of advertising message pleasurable when sung.	Anand and Sternthal (1990)
	Association incongruity	Music associated with an unpleasant experience lowered brand evaluation.	Blair and Shimp (1992)
	Valence congruity	Musical liking enhanced brand attitude.	Mitchell (1988)
		Musical disliking diminished brand attitude.	Simpkins and Smith (1974)
		Musical liking enhanced brand attitude when advertising involvement was low.	Bozman, Muehling, and Pettit-O'Malley (1994); Park and Young (1986)
	Semantic congruity	High congruity between the advertisement's song lyrics and the message enhanced brand attitude with low and high advertising involvement.	MacInnis and Park (1991)
	Genre congruity	High congruity between musical genre and advertising enhanced brand attitude.	Hung (2000, 2001)
Visual recall	Genre congruity	High congruity between musical genre and product attributes enhanced recall of visual imagery from the advertisement.	Gorn, Goldberg, Chattopadhyay, and Litvack (1991); Stewart, Farmer, and Stannard (1990); Stewart and Punj (1998)
Verbal recall	Score congruity	Music composed specifically to be appropriate with an advertisement increased recall levels.	North, Hargreaves, MacKenzie, and Law (2004); Tom (1990); Yalch (1991)
	Image congruity	High music-message congruity (matching evocation of images elicited by the music and the product) enhanced brand name and message recall with attention-gaining music.	Kellaris, Cox, and Cox (1993)

(*continued*)

TABLE 1 (cont'd)

Dependent Variable	Music/Advertising	Outcomes	Studies
Verbal recall (cont'd)	Resolved incongruity	Music fading back in facilitated incongruity resolution and subsequent recall by indicating that the verbal material spoken over unexpected silence was being highlighted due to its importance.	Olsen (1995)
		Participants resolved the incongruity of absent lyrics by singing along, thus enhancing subsequent advertising message recall.	Roehm (2001)
	Tempo/timbre congruity	Recall of radio advertising content was enhanced by increased musical tempo congruity as well as increased musical timbre congruity.	Oakes and North (2006)
Affective response	Timbre congruity	Increased musical timbre congruity enhanced desired affective responses to the advertisement.	Oakes and North (2006)
	Score congruity	Music composed specifically to be appropriate with an advertisement enhanced affective response to the advertisement.	North, Hargreaves, MacKenzie, and Law (2004)

which an advertising agency prepared separate versions of a radio advertisement containing music that was designed to be either appropriate or inappropriate with a product's brand image. They revealed how likelihood of purchasing the advertised product was greater with music designed to be highly congruous with the advertisement compared to less congruous (low fit) advertising music. This study can be categorized as an example of the impact of musical score congruity. Using greeting card slides with happy/sad/no music, Alpert and Alpert (1990) revealed that "happy" music induced significantly happier moods than "sad" music or no music. A later study (Alpert, Alpert, and Maltz, 2005) reported increased product preference and purchase intent where there was congruity between the mood induced by music and the context-specific purchase occasion (e.g., "sad" music was significantly more effective than "happy" music in positively influencing preference and purchase intent of a greeting card for an ill friend). Context-specific mood congruity ensured that the mood of the music was semantically integrated with a key benefit of product acquisition. In conveying sadness to the listener, the music reflected the desire to convey empathetic sadness through the greeting card for the ill friend. This underlined the importance of a match between the mood induced by the music and the mood associated with the advertised product.

When associating slides of pens with liked and disliked music, Gorn (1982) revealed a significant preference for pen colors associated with liked music. However, when Kellaris and Cox (1989) replicated Gorn's classical conditioning experiment with minor modifications to minimize hypothesis guessing, they found no confirmatory evidence. In one experiment, Kellaris and Cox used the same liked/disliked musical genres as Gorn (an Indian classical music extract and a pop song), and in another experiment used liked and disliked compositions by different classical composers, but neither experiment showed an effect on pen color preference. Pitt and Abratt (1988) also concluded that liked (pop) music did not significantly enhance product preference compared to a disliked (classical) stimulus. Consequently, the conflicting evidence means that liked advertising music has not

been included as an empirically verified variable (see Table 1) that impacts significantly upon product preference or purchase intent.

Brand attitude

Although attitudes are often included under the umbrella term of affect, some authors define attitudes in cognitive terms as evaluative judgments rather than emotional states (e.g., Cohen and Areni, 1991), while others regard them as a hybrid of affective and cognitive components (e.g., Breckler and Wiggins, 1989). For the purpose of this research, brand attitude is regarded as a predominantly cognitive component. Anand and Sternthal (1990) revealed significant differences in brand attitudinal responses to a soft drink advertisement using a spoken message compared to the same message sung with musical accompaniment. In contrast to the spoken version, the song displayed a positive, linear trend in terms of enhanced brand evaluation with repeated exposures. These findings underline how music can elicit a more favorable brand attitude over the course of a campaign of repeated advertising exposures. While repetition of the spoken word can become tedious and irritating, song uses rhythmic and tonal variety to support verbal repetition and make it pleasurable, thus leading to repetition congruity.

MacInnis and Park (1991) explored the capacity of music in advertisements to make associations with past emotion-laden experiences (indexicality). Although well-known music offers opportunities for attention gain and positive affect transfer, memories associated with the music may be positive or negative. Because consumers are aware that advertisements try to induce positive attitudes to their brands, music that evokes memories of negative experiences may lead to association incongruity. For example, Blair and Shimp (1992) found that positive brand evaluation declined when slides with a brand name were accompanied by music associated with the negative emotions of an unpleasant experience.

If the background music itself (rather than its autobiographical association) is disliked, valence incongruity arises because the music undermines advertising intention to elicit positive brand attitudes. For example, Simpkins and Smith (1974) revealed how a disliked musical genre (country) accompaniment for an advertising message resulted in significantly lower brand evaluations compared to a liked musical genre (rock) and a no-music treatment. Mitchell (1988) provided a corresponding example of the benefits of valence congruity in a study revealing how advertising music that induced a happy mood produced more positive brand attitudes than advertising music that induced a neutral mood.

Park and Young (1986) chose a number one chart hit as an exemplar of positively valenced (liked) background music and revealed how it enhanced brand attitude (although only for participants with low advertising involvement). Bozman, Mueling, and Pettit-O'Malley (1994) also reported how brand attitude valence was positively related to the valence of affective response to advertising music under conditions of low (but not high) advertising involvement. Despite liking the music, participants in the high advertising involvement condition may have been more skeptical due to the high perceived risk of brand bonding associated with high involvement. In the low-involvement (low perceived risk) condition, brand attitude enhancement may have been more susceptible to musical valence as there would be little need to expend additional cognitive resources evaluating alternative brands.

MacInnis and Park (1991) revealed that high congruity between the advertisement's song lyrics and the advertising message resulted in a more positive emotional response leading to enhanced attitude to the advertisement and brand. Because these findings were consistent under conditions of low and high advertising involvement, it underlines the importance of a high level of semantic congruity between advertising proposition and song. Although involvement level may override valence congruity effects, the positive influence of semantic congruity in negating involvement effects suggests that different forms of musical congruity may be more effective than others. Likewise, Hung (2000) reported how increased congruity between genre of music and advertising subject matter (genre congruity) produced desired decoding of brand attributes (e.g., Brazilian music reinforced perceptions of the natural authenticity of a Brazilian coffee brand). Further research by Hung (2001) revealed how brand attitudes to a television advertisement were significantly altered after superimposing contrasting musical genres (classical and rock) over the advertisement. The congruously up-market classical music treatment reinforced the desired up-market brand image of the advertised shopping mall.

Because the term cognitive involvement has often been used interchangeably to mean product or advertising involvement, this research seeks to clarify the distinction between product involvement (the degree of personal relevance and perceived purchase risk expressed by participants regarding the advertised product) and advertising involvement (the directed attention upon an advertisement and its content in an artificial environment typically using student participants). It should be noted that the three studies of music and brand attitude citing involvement as an independent variable (see Table 1) should be categorized as

examples of advertising involvement, although participants were encouraged to imagine the product had personal relevance for them and to try to learn about brand performance and key benefits in order to simulate product involvement (e.g., Park and Young, 1986).

Recall facilitation

Music was reported to enhance verbal comprehension of advertising messages (Hoyer, Srivastava, and Jacoby, 1984) using a selection of 22 advertisements in which music was either present or absent. However, because advertisements with music may deliberately contain simpler (more easily comprehended) messages to offset the distracting influence of music, results from this study may differ from experimental designs comparing versions of the same advertisement where the message is identical with and without music. Consequently, mere presence of music has not been included as an empirically verified variable that impacts upon recall (Table 1). Much research in the advertising literature has focused upon discriminating between music's ability to draw attention to an advertisement, and its potential to distract the listener from the actual advertising message. For example, unless a song with a deliberately mnemonic element is used, processing of musical data may impinge upon the resources allocated to processing of verbal data, and the inevitable cognitive trade-off is likely to have recall implications. However, the following visual and verbal recall studies explicitly or implicitly reveal the positive impact of musical congruity upon recall.

Visual recall. With visual advertisements, one function of music has been to maintain viewer attention by smoothing out scene changes and binding together sequences of discrete visual images. However, studies using household respondents (e.g., Stewart, Farmer, and Stannard, 1990; Stewart and Punj, 1998) have also found musical cues to be more effective than verbal cues in eliciting recall of visual imagery (action and motion recall) from a montage of car scenes with musical accompaniment. Because the music (exciting hard rock) was intended to evoke the key product benefit (exciting to drive), positive results can be attributed to the benefits of congruity between musical genre and advertisement (genre congruity). Although no musical genre was explicitly stated, Gorn, Goldberg, Chattopadhyay, and Litvack (1991) reported significantly increased visual recall using advertising music (compared to no music) that was selected by a studio musician as representative of the style of advertising music normally associated with the generic product (apple juice).

Verbal recall. Empirical studies have examined the effects induced by jingles, instrumental background music, and chart hits. The importance of ensuring congruity between advertising music and brand has been highlighted by research (e.g., Tom, 1990) revealing that well-known chart hits were less effective in generating brand recall than music scored specifically for its appropriateness with an advertising campaign. In accord, Yalch (1991) revealed that jingles scored specifically for an advertisement enhanced brand name recall (although the recall benefits of the jingle versus no-jingle treatment diminished with increasing advertising exposures, implying that jingles may be more productive in low-exposure campaigns). North, Hargreaves, MacKenzie, and Law (2004) also revealed how content recall was significantly higher with musical stimuli evaluated as highly congruous with the advertisement compared to less congruous (low fit) advertising music. These three studies can be categorized as examples of the way in which congruity between advertisement and musical score (score congruity) enhances verbal recall.

MacInnis and Park's (1991) concept of "music's fit with the ad" relates to the congruity between two types of verbal cue (advertising copy and song lyrics). This differs from the concept of music-message congruity (the fit between advertising copy and instrumental music) developed by Kellaris, Cox, and Cox (1993), who found that attention-gaining music with high music-message congruity had a positive effect on brand name and message recall. In the latter study, retention was reinforced when the images evoked by advertised products matched the images evoked by different pieces of music (image congruity). However, when congruity was low, music (either high or low in attention-gain) distracted attention and impeded advertising processing and subsequent recall. Results revealed that only music high in attention-gain and music-message congruity could outperform a no-music condition in terms of brand name and message recall. They suggested that it is essential for advertising music and message elements to complement each other rather than compete for attention.

Although music may contribute to advertising message reception by attracting and holding attention, it may become so captivating that it actually distracts attention from the main advertising message. Brooker and Wheatley (1994) reported how background music reduced unaided verbal recall of an advertisement compared to a treatment in which music was only used as an introduction and faded out when the voice message was introduced. Olsen (1995) developed this finding in reporting a significant increase in recall when advertisements with music cut to silence just before presentation of crucial verbal content. This indicates the importance of using musical dynamics in advertisements (including

more subtle volume gradations from loud to soft) in order to gain attention and facilitate enhanced recall. The study revealed how the radical dynamic incongruity of unexpected silence enhanced recall compared to background music or background silence throughout. Dramatic pause jolted the listener and directed attention to verbal content through attention-focusing juxtaposition of the expected and unexpected. Because the background music faded back in after presentation of the verbal content, it facilitated resolution of the incongruity by allowing participants to realize that the verbal material spoken over silence was being highlighted due to its importance.

Another example of incongruity resolution can be found in a study by Roehm (2001), who revealed that day-after verbal recall of lyrics containing the advertising brand message was greater with instrumental (no lyrics) rather than vocal versions of a pop song for respondents familiar with the song. Because a familiar song presented without its normal lyrics may be considered incongruous with expectations, participants had attempted to resolve the incongruity by actively generating (singing along with) the absent lyrics, thus enhancing subsequent recall. In this context, incongruity can actually enhance content recall provided that the listener can participate in its resolution, perhaps suggesting that advertisers should consider using instrumental versions of songs if the target audience is likely to be highly familiar with the song.

Previous studies examining the impact of music upon temporal perception used digital technology to isolate the discrete musical variables of mode (Kellaris and Kent, 1992), volume (Kellaris and Altsech, 1992), and tempo (Oakes, 2003b). Consistent with the design of these studies, Oakes and North (2006) used digital technology to superimpose contrasting musical tempi and timbres over radio advertisements. Retrospective recall of brand name and featured benefit was enhanced with increased congruity between these structural characteristics of music and the advertisement. In the first experiment, slow-tempo background music (90 beats per minute) in an advertisement produced significantly higher levels of advertising content recall compared to fast-tempo music (170 beats per minute). Because it is unusual to hear music faster than 120 beats per minute in an advertisement (Kellaris and Rice, 1993), Oakes and North suggested that it was the incongruity of the fast-tempo treatment (tempo incongruity) that distracted cognitive resources from processing of advertising message content. In the second experiment, three background musical timbres (piano, church organ, and steel drum) differed in their congruity with a radio advertisement for cosmetic surgery (the piano timbre was most congruous and the steel drum timbre was least congruous). Results revealed a positive main effect of timbre congruity upon recall of advertising content. Table 1 highlights verbal and visual recall studies from a musical congruity perspective.

AFFECTIVE RESPONSE

Oakes and North (2006) reported a positive main effect of timbre congruity upon desired affective responses to the advertisement (the most congruous timbre produced significantly happier, more calming, and more relaxing responses). North, Hargreaves, MacKenzie, and Law (2004) also revealed how a high level of musical score congruity enhanced positive affective response to the advertisement. Although most of the studies identified in Table 1 focused upon desired cognitive outcomes, it is important to highlight the impact of affective response. While the spoken word in an advertisement can provide objective product attribute information that consumers can cognitively evaluate, accompanying background music may be used to evoke more of an emotional response. The deliberate segregation of cognitive and emotional response acknowledges inherent ambiguity portrayed by previous research (e.g., Zajonc, 1980), suggesting that "feeling is not free of thought, nor is thought free of feeling." This underlines the difficulty in attempting to divorce emotional and cognitive response to advertisements, because cognitive messages may have emotional undertones, while emotional stimulation through mood inducing music may elicit involuntary cognitive processing that ultimately impacts upon purchase behavior. Although emotional response to advertising may be regarded as an antecedent of cognitive response in many contexts (e.g., brand attitude formation), there is considerable ambiguity regarding the specification of a consistent one-way directionality in the linear relationship between emotion and cognition.

Research regarding the directionality of the complex hypothesized relationship between emotion and cognition is equivocal. Bagozzi, Gopinath, and Nyer (1999) suggested that before an emotional response can take place, individuals must cognitively appraise an event in which they have a personal stake. In apparent directional contrast, they also reported how emotions function centrally to influence cognitive processes and suggested that positive moods lead to increased or decreased cognitive processing depending on whether the message will maintain or threaten their mood. However, in categorizing brand attitude as a cognitive component, most of the studies identified in this literature review appear to suggest that affective responses to music are antecedents of cognitive responses. For example, several of the attitudinal studies reported how the emotional response of

musical liking significantly enhanced brand attitude (Bozman, Mueling, and Pettit-O'Malley, 1994; Mitchell, 1988; Park and Young, 1986; Simpkins and Smith, 1974). However, the clearest evidence of directionality was demonstrated by MacInnis and Park (1991). They reported a unidirectional link from cognitive evaluation of high semantic congruity to positive emotional response and subsequently positive brand attitude. In the purchase intent study of Alpert, Alpert, and Maltz (2005), affective and cognitive responses were overtly interdependent through measurement of mood induction within the context of cognitive awareness of mood incongruity.

Hung (2001) revealed how emotional response to music can transfer directly to the advertisement itself. However, evaluation of affective response to the musical stimuli used in these studies acknowledges that although music is capable of eliciting an emotional intensity beyond the capacity of verbal description, advertising music often relies upon bland clichés designed to trigger emotions that are mainly socially conditioned. Effective musical communication in an advertising context may be dependent upon consumer prior exposure to comparable musical stimuli that has resulted in learning of the underlying cultural conventions and symbolic resonance of such stimuli.

Effective musical communication in an advertising context may be dependent upon consumer prior exposure to comparable musical stimuli that has resulted in learning of the underlying cultural conventions and symbolic resonance of such stimuli.

DISCUSSION

Analysis of the empirical studies has distinguished among 10 variants of music/advertising congruity (mood, repetition, association, valence, semantic, genre, score, image, tempo, and timbre). Score, image, tempo, and timbre congruity have been reported to enhance verbal recall, while genre congruity enhanced visual recall. Increased musical score congruity and timbre congruity resulted in enhanced affective response to the advertisement. The evidence also suggested that increased musical score congruity and mood congruity enhance purchase intent. However, further research is required to confirm the intuitive link between liked advertising music and purchase intent.

Results confirmed that high congruity between musical genre and advertisement leads to more positive brand attitudes. Music and brand information are interconnected in advertising jingles because the lyrics form an integral part of the musical composition. The rhythmic and tonal variety of song was revealed to make verbal repetition of advertising message more pleasurable through repetition congruity, thus leading to enhanced brand attitude. Likewise, a high level of semantic congruity between the advertisement's song lyrics and the message was reported to enhance brand attitude. Although instrumental music is comparatively disconnected from the verbalized advertising narrative it supports, the empirical studies suggest that instrumental music should be perceived to be as congruous as possible with the advertisement in order to create a seamless (less distracting) fusion of words and music. There was consistency in suggesting that the valence of musical liking induces correspondingly valenced brand attitudes (valence congruity). Findings also revealed how the valence of memories associated with a piece of music correspond to brand attitudes when this music is used to accompany an advertising message, thus underlining the importance of association congruity.

Kellaris, Cox, and Cox (1993) reported how the level of attention-gain of the music interacted with image congruity to impact upon recall. While further research is required to assess the extent to which attention-gain may interact with other variants of musical congruity, it underlines the need to be aware of potentially interacting variables. Although the different forms of music/advertising congruity are presented as discrete items depending upon the focus of the individual studies from which they are drawn, it should be acknowledged that the categories are not mutually exclusive. For example, use of jazz within an advertisement may be capable of eliciting responses demonstrating various combinations of genre, valence, mood, association, image, tempo, and timbre congruity. Indeed, future research could consider the interactive effects that arise when advertising music responses demonstrate a mixture of positive (congruous) and negative (incongruous) combinations.

When focusing upon valence congruity, regardless of whether a piece of advertising music is liked or disliked, it is possible that cultural attitudes to a musical genre or subgenre may impact upon brand attitude. While a rock and roll composition in an advertisement targeting the youth market may be liked by younger respondents, the musical subgenre may

still be associated with the culture of a previous generation (genre incongruity), thus providing a potentially deleterious influence upon brand attitude that would not have resulted from use of a liked composition in a more contemporary pop music style. For example, Pirelli's urban marketing campaign demonstrated a high level of congruity between the advertising message and the contemporary hip-hop subgenre by using rap music to target youthful tire buyers. The benefits of genre congruity were evident as hip-hop reinforced perceptions of the streetwise, urban credibility of the Pirelli brand.

In addition to supporting the spoken word, music in television and cinema advertising typically emphasizes the visual images on screen. Because consumers are accustomed to the cinematic convention of using music to complement visual expression, audiovisual advertising that does not synchronize music and movement may flout consumer expectations. Marshall and Cohen (1988) reported enhanced visual attention when film music shared temporal accent patterns with the moving images on screen. Consequently, future advertising research needs to build upon such research in assessing the impact upon desired cognitive outcomes of manipulating the congruity of choreography between music and visual movement. Although advertising music is brief in duration, advertisers need to be aware of the principles of musical communication that are fundamental to compositions of any duration. Because Olsen (1995) has demonstrated the recall facilitation effectiveness of the dramatic transition from music to silence, future research could explore the impact of dramatically varying the structural characteristics of musical stimuli within an advertisement (e.g., tempo and key) in order to elicit desired affective and cognitive responses.

Although the findings highlighted in Table 1 are consistent in endorsing increased musical congruity with the advertisement, the implications for advertising practitioners need further clarification. Many of the findings appear to confirm intuitive expectations because advertisers are aware that there are benefits to be gained from using liked music (valence congruity), appropriate musical genres (genre congruity), and chart hits or repetitively sung jingles (repetition congruity) with a clear relationship between the advertisement's song lyrics and the message (semantic congruity). For example, the campaign to launch Microsoft Windows 95 demonstrated semantic congruity between the title of The Rolling Stones' hit ("Start Me Up") and the booting up of a computer. These congruity variables are generally controllable for advertisers. However, although a popular and well-known piece of music may be liked by most consumers, it may bring back memories of an unpleasant experience for some of them, thus lowering brand evaluation. Such association incongruity is generally uncontrollable for advertisers.

Regarding the structural characteristics of music, advertisers can ensure that musical tempo does not fall short of or exceed expected parameters (tempo congruity) and can ensure that the musical instruments used are the most appropriate for the advertised product and message (timbre congruity). Use of an original composition produced specifically for its appropriateness with an advertising campaign (score congruity) increases the degree of control an advertiser has over many of the other variants of music/advertising congruity because the composition can be customized to meet precise communicative requirements. With effective pretesting, an original composition can be designed to ensure high congruity between the mood induced by the music and the product (mood congruity), and to match evocation of images elicited by the music and the product (image congruity). More thorough pretesting may well have detected the image incongruity evident in a campaign for Nissan North America's Titan truck that featured "Colonel Bogey March" (a tune whistled by World War II allied prisoners of war while being forced to build a bridge for their Japanese captors in the 1957 film *The Bridge on the River Kwai*). The desired, positive image of Nissan as a Japanese company was in conflict with the negative images of the Japanese soldiers evoked by the tune. The music was subsequently dropped after consumer complaints. Likewise, some campaigns have displayed apparently undetected semantic incongruity between the advertisement's song lyrics and the message. For example, Iggy Pop's "Lust for Life" (a song about heroin addiction) was used in a Royal Caribbean Cruise Line advertisement depicting healthy and active passengers.

However, despite the unanimous endorsement of congruous advertising music demonstrated in Table 1, many innovative advertising campaigns have not simply used uniformly congruous music. Advertising practitioners have frequently used verbal and visual incongruity resolution to convey humor (Spotts, Weinberger, and Parsons, 1997) in order to enhance attitude to the advertisement and encourage consumers to decode the communicative purpose of the humor. For example, Heckler and Childers (1992) discussed an advertisement in which a famous rap singer sounded incongruously like a cabaret singer after drinking the wrong brand of cola, thus using musical incongruity to deposition a competitor product. Rather than using musical incongruity merely as a device to gain attention, there is evidence to suggest that advertising practitioners have used it in a creative fashion to complement the advertising message. Interpretive research by

Scott (1990) has identified examples of advertisements using music in a purposeful and artfully incongruous manner, including use of the musical device of transition from tension to release. For example, an advertisement for a pain relief product used the resolution from musical dissonance to consonance as a metaphor for effective pain relief. Through cognitive resolution of the underlying purpose of the initially incongruous dissonance, music has functioned as a rhetorical device that complements verbal and visual communication regarding product benefits. These practitioner examples clearly indicate the benefits of selective use of musical incongruity.

When incongruity is perceived in an advertising context, consumers are likely to assume there is a deliberately underlying communicative purpose for its presence.

Theoretical arguments supporting the use of musical incongruity in advertisements

Empirical evidence from the studies highlighted in Table 1 appears to suggest that increased music/advertising congruity contributes synergistically to enhance communications effectiveness in terms of purchase intent, brand attitude, advertising content recall, and affective response. Indeed, theoretical psychological evidence can be provided to support these findings, particularly regarding recall. For example, memory has been represented as networks of nodes linking elements of thought through associative pathways along which a congruous stimulus can facilitate memory network linkages and enhance recall (Furnham, Bergland, and Gunter, 2002). This suggests that recall would not be enhanced through an incongruous stimulus as it would not activate related constructs along network linkages. When incongruity is perceived in an advertising context, consumers are likely to assume there is a deliberately underlying communicative purpose for its presence. However, when cognitive processing attempts to make linkages through memory in order to rationalize the purpose of the incongruity, the fruitless search for meaning through a labyrinth of networks ultimately only distracts attention from the advertising message.

This argument is supported in a study of background music within films (Boltz, Schulkind, and Kantra, 1991) revealing how recall of filmed events was greater when the mood of the scene and the accompanying music were congruous with each other. However, with foreshadowing music (presented prior to the filmed event as a signal of what is to follow), they reported how recall was greater with incongruous music. For advertisers seeking to attract attention to their advertisement using the novelty and surprise of incongruous music, this underlines the potential importance of the relative placement of the music. Incongruous music that is played concurrently during the exposition of the advertising message may simply distract from the cognitive processing of advertising content by focusing attention upon the music as much as the advertisement. In contrast, if the music is played prior to the exposition of the advertising message, the incongruity is only apparent when the music fades out and the message exposition begins, thus focusing attention upon advertising content.

Findings from studies using nonmusical stimuli also provide a theoretical counterargument supporting the use of incongruity in advertisements. Various studies (e.g., Miniard et al., 1991) have reported how information that is incongruous with prior expectations leads to more effortful and elaborate processing that increases the number of associative memory pathways. In identifying relevancy and expectancy as distinct components of congruity, Heckler and Childers (1992) reported how elaborative processing efforts were highest with unexpected and relevant information. They suggested that an incongruous advertising stimulus is more effective in penetrating the perceptual screen of an audience to attract attention to an advertisement and proposed that an unexpected and relevant incongruous stimulus enhances identification of the primary theme and message of an advertisement. The relevance of the material allows the formation of associative linkages that enhance the probability of successful advertising content retrieval. In this context, relevant and unexpected (partially incongruous) stimuli are more effective than irrelevant and unexpected (incongruous), and relevant and expected (congruous) stimuli. This would suggest that the consistent pattern of results observable in Table 1 may be due to the use of incongruous musical stimuli in many of the studies that are both irrelevant and unexpected.

In accord with research (Heckler and Childers, 1992) reporting the benefits of using incongruous advertising stimuli containing unexpected and relevant information, McQuarrie and Mick (1999) identified the importance of verbal and visual incongruity resolution. They revealed how the deliberate crafting of incongruity can be used to engage and entertain consumers, and proposed a hypothetical continuum of artful deviation (advertising stimulus

Consequently, future empirical research is needed to evaluate the relatively neglected potential of selective use of creative and purposeful musical incongruity in advertising.

incongruity) suggesting that consumer resolution of such incongruity enhances advertising interest levels. For example, the subtly deliberate incongruity of verbal or visual metaphor has frequently been used to enhance communication objectives and reinforce the advertising proposition. Both verbal and visual incongruity have been reported to elicit enhanced semantic processing (McQuarrie and Mick, 1996) and recall (Houston, Childers, and Heckler, 1987) as listeners seek meaningful reconciliation of the deliberate violation of expectations they have encountered.

In categorizing many of the incongruous musical stimuli highlighted in this research as examples of unexpected and irrelevant incongruity, they fall short of the artful deviation characteristic of such verbal and visual incongruity because they do not set out to elicit interpretations capable of reinforcing the advertising proposition. Rather than using deliberately artful deviation to locate the musical stimuli within a zone of interpretive ambiguity capable of nurturing metaphorical elaboration, deviation from musical expectations is often polarized and devoid of implicit resonance for the advertising message. In support of this argument, the two recall studies that allowed musical incongruity resolution (Olsen, 1995; Roehm, 2001) did produce enhanced recall levels. While a congruous musical stimulus is likely to be integrated with other communicative elements of the advertisement, this underlines the effectiveness of using artfully incongruous music that demonstrates coherent integration with the advertising message. Consequently, future empirical research is needed to evaluate the relatively neglected potential of selective use of creative and purposeful musical incongruity in advertising. JAR

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